INDIVIDUAL BRIEF · WEEK 10 · TECHNOLOGIST

Before an agent, a mirror

Nicolas Martinez · Crystal Ball Studio · AI 2041, ch. 9 “Isle of Happiness” · Vacuum: **Debt guardrails**

1. My angle

The other four lenses will argue about what an agent working for the buyer should do. I bring a different question: **what can that agent read today, and with whose permission?** On AI Saeida everything works because a *middleware* layer connects the data from every platform; Kai-Fu Lee calls it “the Isle,” a trusted AI that answers on your behalf. In Mexico that pipe does not exist. A buyer's agent only gets in through doors the seller builds, and the only source the buyer fully controls is their own screen.

My lens separates what is **commodity** (reasoning, comparing, extracting text), what is **hard** (access, trust, completeness) and what is **fake** (a “neutral agent” that lives inside the store).

2. The technology, honestly

Test 1 — Access (Oct 17, 2026). I read the robots.txt of four retailers the way an agent would. Liverpool explicitly allows GPTBot, ChatGPT-User, ClaudeBot, Claude-User and PerplexityBot (file updated Aug 20, 2026). Mercado Libre and Amazon Mexico refused automated access under their robots rules. Coppel blocked me with bot detection. The rails that are opening are built by sellers and payment processors: Google's Universal Commerce Protocol (January 2026; Shopify, Walmart and Target among its co-developers) and the Santander-Visa pilot in which agents bought in Mexico and four other countries, always at participating merchants.

Test 2 — Extraction (my own). I generated three fictional BNPL payment calendars (12 installments, unbranded providers, no real people's data), ran them through Tesseract OCR and summed the debt per *quincena* (Mexico's twice-monthly pay period).

Input	Read correctly	Debt, 1st Nov. quincena (actual: $2,490.50)	Failure
Clean screenshot	12 / 12	$2,490.50	none
Simulated phone photo (tilted, blurred, JPEG)	10 / 12	$2,141.50 (−14%)	day “1” read as “L”; a January payment vanished

All 12 amounts were always read; two dates failed. The serious part is that **the error is silent**: the tool underestimates debt without warning, in exactly the dangerous direction. Catching it is cheap: if there are more amounts than dates, ask the user. I did not test a vision model; it would probably read better, but it charges per image and sends the screenshot to a third party.

Verdict. Commodity: extracting, summing, explaining. Hard: completeness and freshness (with no API, the user has to upload screenshots again). Fake: the “neutral” agent of a platform that also lends money and sells ads.

3. The world's best attempt

- **India — Account Aggregators (RBI).** Licensed intermediaries that move financial data under a signed “consent artefact”: purpose, data type, dates and duration, revocable at any time. They cannot read what they carry and are barred from doing any other business. As of Dec 31, 2025: 2.61 billion accounts enabled and 252.9 million users. They got right what Lee leaves open: whoever holds your data gains nothing by selling you something.
- **United Kingdom — BNPL under the FCA (since July 15, 2026).** Affordability checks before every loan, repayment dates and charges up front, support in financial difficulty, and access to the

Financial Ombudsman. Australia did the same in June 2025. They got right that BNPL is credit, not a "payment method."

• **Translation to Mexico.** It hasn't arrived because both the pipe and the rule are missing. The transactional-data rules under Article 76 of the Fintech Law were never published (only open data, in 2020), so no neutral aggregator is possible via API. I found no Mexican affordability rule specific to BNPL, while the market grows 27.6% to US$5.08 billion in 2026. What breaks at the border: (1) with no API, the input is a screenshot; (2) the cycle is the *quincena*, not the month; (3) many people pay in cash at stores, so not even the bank sees all the debt; (4) INAI was dissolved in 2025 and data protection moved to the Anti-Corruption and Good Governance Ministry, so the design cannot rely on a strong regulator.

4. The vacuum I'd attack: Debt guardrails

Through my lens it is the only one of the four that can be built today with commodity tools and **without the seller's permission**.

• **Buyer's agent:** access is controlled by the seller (Test 1). Today it would be a seller's recommendation wearing a different face: the forbidden zone in disguise.

• **Regret prevention:** requires predicting future regret. Lee himself admits AI cannot tell whether a change comes from today or from last year. It is the hardest problem in the chapter.

• **Tiendita digitization:** real, but digital restocking is already contested by apps like Rabbit (205,000+ stores), funded from the supplier side.

What I would build: "Mi Quincena." The user uploads screenshots of their BNPL payment calendars; the app extracts dates and amounts and shows how much they owe in each *quincena*, across all providers. Before a new purchase they type the amount and see: "this adds $X to your Nov 15 *quincena*; you already owe $Y." Today nobody in Mexico shows the buyer that cross-provider total.

5. The shadow

The chapter dramatizes two harms. **Blind consent:** Viktor taps "I consent" without reading and later learns that leaving costs a penalty tied to the total value of his assets; that is how a BNPL gets signed. **Paternalism:** Akilah decides what will make Viktor happy, feeds him fake news and leaves him in the desert "for his own good." Four design decisions:

1. Show, never block. The app cannot cancel, stop or delay a purchase. It only shows the number; the decision belongs to the user.

2. Zero seller-side revenue. No lender commissions, no affiliates, no ads, written into the terms, like the Indian ban.

3. Minimal data, against Lee. The image is deleted after extraction; only date, amount and a user-chosen label are stored. No access to email or banking.

4. Never undercount silently. If OCR reads more amounts than dates, the app asks before summing.

6. My opening position for Team Bending

Half agree. Personalization does make people worse at deciding: it is Mahdi's algorithm, which satisfies the craving and leaves the user on the hedonic treadmill. Lee says it in one line: when the interest of the AI's owner diverges from the user's, the user loses. But returns don't prove it: the figures for Mexico range from 16.9% to 52.9% depending on the source. **The proof is debt. A blouse can be returned; a quincena can't.** And as the Technologist I add one more thing: the buyer's agent everyone will want to build has no way in. Before we give the buyer an agent, let's give them a mirror.

Sources: AI 2041, ch. 9 and analysis · liverpool.com.mx robots.txt (Oct 17, 2026) · Ecosistema Startup, "Retailers en México: 0 de 11 listos para agentes" · Forbes Argentina, agentic commerce in LATAM (May 2026) · HyperVerge, Account Aggregator Framework 2026 · FStech, "BNPL lenders face FCA oversight from July 2026" · Fiskil, Open Finance Tracker Mexico · Xataka México, BNPL market 2026 · Merca2.0 (52.9%) and InformaBTL (16.9%), returns · Forbes México, Rabbit · Hogan Lovells, Mexico's new data protection law 2025. OCR test: fictional data, own script.